Modelantwoord huiswerk wg2

Privacy as the Cornerstone of Freedom

In contemporary democracies, privacy is often treated as a luxury or a negotiable convenience. We trade it away for free services, quick logins, and targeted recommendations. Yet privacy is far more that a confort; it is a precondition for genuine individual freedom. [HOOFDSTELLING] A citizen who knows that every search, message, and movement is recorded behaves differently from one who can explore ideas, relationships, and projects without being constantly watched.

If citizens cannot control who accesses their personal data, then they cannot make truly autonomous life choices. Autonomy requires that we can experiment with our beliefs, connections, and ambitions without fear that every step will be judged by an unseen audience. In modern digital societies, citizens increasingly lose control over their personal data—through pervasive data collection by platforms and states alike. Therefore, citizens in these societies cannot make truly autonomous life choices. A society that undermines autonomy in this way undermines freedom itself.

Voorbeeld MP
Premisse 1: If citizens cannot control who accesses their personal data, then they cannot make truly autonomous life choices.
Premisse 2: Citizens increasingly lose control over their personal data.
Conclusie: Therefore, citizens in these societies cannot make truly autonomous life choices.

Supporters of mass surveillance sometimes argue that, by monitoring everyone “just in case,” the state protects freedom from threats such as terrorism. But consider the following: if mass surveillance genuinely increased citizens’ freedom, we would observe more robust civic participation—greater protest, more controversial speech, and wider political experimentation. In reality, in states that expand surveillance powers, we do not see more robust civic participation; instead, people often self-censor and avoid political risks. Therefore, mass surveillance does not genuinely increase citizens’ freedom. It erodes it.

Voorbeeld MT
Premisse 1: If mass surveillance genuinely increased citizens’ freedom, we would observe more robust civic participation.
Premisse 2: In states that expand surveillance powers, we do not see more robust civic participation.
Conclusie: Therefore, mass surveillance does not genuinely increase citizens’ freedom.

We should be clear about the structural role of privacy in limiting state power. If privacy protections are strong, then abuse of state power is less likely, because officials cannot easily track and intimidate dissenters. If abuse of state power is less likely, then individual freedom is more secure, since citizens can oppose policies without fear of targeted retaliation. Hence, if privacy protections are strong, individual freedom is more secure. This is not a mere preference; it follows from the logic of how information can be used to control or liberate citizens.

Voorbeeld voor een andere vorm van geldige redenering (hypothetical syllogism)
Premisse 1: If privacy protections are strong, then abuse of state power is less likely.
Premisse 2: If abuse of state power is less likely, then individual freedom is more secure.
Conclusie: Hence, if privacy protections are strong, individual freedom is more secure.

Some policymakers claim that technological measures make worries about freedom obsolete. They point out that, after the introduction of a nationwide data-retention program five years ago, recorded petty crime rates decreased. They then conclude that the data-retention program caused the reduction in crime and therefore enhanced citizens' freedom. But t*his jumps from correlation to causation without considering alternative explanations: changes in economic conditions, policing strategies, or reporting practices. By assuming that "after" means "because of," such reasoning wrongly treats any decline in crime as proof that bulk data collection is what makes us free.*

Public attitudes to privacy are also often misrepresented. A minister once remarked that "people who care about privacy usually have something to hide," and cited a handful of high-profile cases in which criminals used encryption to conceal wrongdoing. From these examples, she inferred that, in general, anyone insisting on strong privacy protections is probably hiding something suspicious. *This is a false generalisation: from a few sensational cases, she extrapolates to a sweeping claim about all privacy-conscious citizens. In reality, journalists, activists, and ordinary people use privacy tools precisely to protect legitimate expression and association, not to commit crimes.*

We do face genuine security threats, and governments must respond to them. But treating privacy as expendable is a dangerous strategy. Either we place meaningful limits on data collection, or we accept a continuing erosion of privacy. We cannot reasonably accept a continuing erosion of privacy, because it gradually silences dissent and chills experimentation—the very practices that sustain a free society. Therefore, we must place meaningful limits on data collection. A democratic community that understands this will defend privacy not as a niche concern, but as the everyday architecture of its freedom.